

Third Shot Drop

1. Lesson Recap

The third shot drop is a soft, arcing shot the serving team hits from near the baseline, aiming to land the ball gently in or just past your opponents' non-volley zone — the kitchen. It is the third shot of the rally: serve, return, then drop.

Its job is not to win the point outright. After the return, your opponents are usually already at the kitchen line with the advantage. The drop neutralizes that advantage by forcing them to hit up off a low, soft ball, which buys you and your partner time to move forward and join them at the net — where most points are won.

When the ball peaks on your side of the net and drops low into the kitchen, you have turned a defensive moment into an even playing field.

2. Big Idea

The third shot drop is a transition shot, not a winner — think "long dink."

If you remember one thing, make it this: you are trying to land a soft, unattackable ball in the kitchen so you can move up, not blast a winner past your opponents. Soft hands, a gentle lift, and patience get you to the net far more often than power does.

3. Key Cues

- "Loose grip — about a 3 out of 10."
- "Lift, don't hit."
- "Low to high, compact swing."
- "Contact out in front."
- "Move from the shoulder, quiet wrist."
- "Let the ball peak on my side."
- "Make them hit up."
- "Cross-court for more room."
- "Move in only after a good drop."
- "Stay back if I pop it up."

4. Step-by-Step

1. Set up balanced near the baseline after your serve, knees soft and weight under control.
2. Read the return. If it is deep or heavy, give yourself time and do not rush the shot.
3. Hold the paddle with a relaxed grip and a slightly open face. Keep the backswing short.
4. Let the ball drop after the bounce into a comfortable contact zone, around knee to thigh height.
5. Make contact out in front of your body with a smooth low-to-high motion, driven by your shoulder — not a flick of the wrist.
6. Lift the ball into a soft arc that peaks on your side of the net and falls into the kitchen.
7. Follow through up toward shoulder height to control distance, keeping the swing slow and long rather than fast and short.
8. Favor cross-court when you can — the net is lower in the middle and the court is longer, giving you more margin.
9. After a good drop, move forward with your partner and split step as your opponent contacts the ball.
10. If your drop is too high or attackable, stay back, reset, and try again on the fifth or seventh shot.

5. Common Mistakes

- Hitting too hard: The ball sails deep or sits up for an easy attack. Loosen your grip and think "long dink," not drive.
- Swinging too big: A long backswing kills control. Keep the motion compact and let the legs and shoulder do the work.
- Using the wrist: Flicking the wrist adds a second hinge point and causes pop-ups and net errors. Move from the shoulder with a quiet wrist.
- Hitting down on the ball: A drop needs lift. Start the paddle below the ball and swing upward.
- Late contact: Meeting the ball behind you sends it into the net or pops it up. Take it out in front as it descends.
- Rushing forward automatically: Charging in after a weak drop gets you attacked. Only move up when the drop is good; otherwise hold and reset.

6. Self-Check

- Am I using a relaxed grip and soft hands?
- Did I keep my backswing short and compact?
- Did I contact the ball in front of my body?
- Was the swing low to high, driven by my shoulder?
- Did the ball peak on my side of the net?
- Did the drop make my opponent hit up?
- Did I move forward only after a good drop?
- Did I stay back and reset when the drop was attackable?

7. Homework 🏠

Practice these before your next play session:

- Shadow drop swings: Without a ball, rehearse 15 compact low-to-high swings, feeling the lift come from your shoulder and legs with a quiet wrist.
- Self-feed drops: From near the baseline, drop-feed a ball to yourself and hit 25 soft drops into the kitchen. Focus on a relaxed grip and contact out in front.
- Cross-court target drill: Place a towel or paddle cover in the kitchen. Hit 20 drops toward it from each side, favoring the cross-court path.
- Slinky drill: Start near the net and hit easy drops, taking a step back after each one until you reach the baseline. Add a little more follow-through as you move back. This grooves distance control.
- Drop-and-move drill: Hit a drop, take two or three controlled steps forward, then split step. Do 10 reps, prioritizing balance over speed.
- Awareness task: During recreational play, notice whether each third shot made your opponent hit up, attack, or take it comfortably out of the air.

8. Game Application 🎮

Use the third shot drop when the returning team is already at the kitchen line and you need time to advance. Your target is the kitchen, most often cross-court or toward your opponent's weaker side.

Do not force it every time. If the return lands short and high, a controlled drive may be the smarter play. If the return pushes you deep or off balance, focus on a safe, soft shot and staying in the rally rather than attempting a perfect drop.

In doubles, move as a unit. A good drop lets both you and your partner advance together. A weak one means both of you should hold, defend, and look to drop again on the fifth or seventh shot. Patience here wins more points than any single great shot.

9. Visualization 👁️

Before you play, picture yourself behind the baseline after a deep serve, calm and balanced. You see the return coming back and you give yourself time.

Imagine relaxing your grip, letting the ball drop to thigh height, and lifting smoothly through it from your shoulder. You watch the ball float up in a soft arc, peak on your side of the net, clear it by a comfortable margin, and settle into the kitchen. Your opponent has to reach down and lift it back. You and your partner move forward together, split step, and arrive at the line ready — patient, controlled, and in the point.

10. Quick Reminders

- Loose grip, soft hands.
- Compact swing, low to high.
- Contact out in front.
- Aim for the kitchen, not the baseline.
- Make them hit up.
- Cross-court gives you more room.
- Move in only after a good drop.
- If it pops up, stay back and try again.

11. Resources

Use these resources for optional review away from the court. The notes above are your main practice plan.

Articles

- [Basics Of The Third Shot Drop](#)
Source: USA Pickleball
An official, beginner-friendly overview of what the shot is, why the serving team needs it, and the soft mechanics that make it work.
- [How to Improve Your Third Shot Drop in Pickleball](#)
Source: Selkirk Sport
Three focused tips — moving from the shoulder, extending the follow-through, and setting your feet near the baseline — plus the "slinky drill" for distance control.
- [Third Shot Drop Pickleball: 3rd Shot Guide](#)
Source: The Dink Pickleball
A thorough guide covering grip pressure, a compact swing, semi-open stance, contact point, and smart cross-court placement.

YouTube Videos

- [How To Hit A Perfect 3rd Shot Drop](#)
Channel: Briones Pickleball
Jordan Briones breaks down spacing, swing speed, and contact point so you stop hitting the ball late and high.
- [The UNTOLD Truth About 3rd Shot Drops in Pickleball](#)
Channel: Zane Navratil Pickleball
A pro's simple reframe — the drop is really just a long dink — that takes the pressure off and makes the shot easier to repeat.
- [How to Hit a 3rd Shot Drop in Pickleball](#)
Channel: That Pickleball School
A clear fundamentals walkthrough of the soft touch, lift, and ball flight needed to land the ball in the kitchen.

Rules and Strategy References

- [USA Pickleball Rules Summary](#)
Source: USA Pickleball
Review the two-bounce rule and non-volley zone basics. They explain why the serving team starts back and why a soft drop into the kitchen is so valuable.
- [Mastering The Third Shot In Pickleball: Drop Vs. Drive](#)
Source: USA Pickleball
A strategy explainer on when to choose the drop versus a drive, so you know when the shot is the right call.